competition and turned up in full force for the event. I ran as one possessed, very much aware of Nimmi's presence. There was absolutely no question of me losing the race, not with Nimmi as an onlooker. I wanted to impress her and it would just be too humiliating if I lost. When I won, I stood before Nimmi and was thrilled by the glow of happiness on her face.

At the dinner party, Nimmi discussed my race in minute detail, and I was struck by how interested she was in my life and career. It seemed obvious that we were on the brink of a new relationship, and I was determined to see her again, but we were at a party and I had no card or piece of paper to write down my telephone number. So quietly, lest anyone could see, I caught hold of her hand and quickly wrote the number down on her palm. My touch made her blush and she nervously looked around, wiping the sweat from her brow with her dupatta. The rush of emotions that swept across me electrified me and I couldn't sleep a wink that night. The next morning, before she left for India, Nimmi telephoned me and we agreed to meet at the Yadavindra Stadium in Patiala, where I practised regularly, when I was with my unit there.

When I returned to Patiala from Colombo two days later, I received a telephone call from the principal of the College of Physical Education, who informed me that some of his students, including Nimmi, were coming to watch me practice. She had wisely taken this precaution in case our growing relationship would lead to gossip. When I met the principal, I congratulated him on the volleyball team's victory in Colombo and made special mention of Nimmi's contribution.

Nimmi and I met a couple of times thereafter, while we were both practising at the stadium—she volleyball and I running. But there were few outward signs that our relationship was ripening into love. All it amounted to, at that stage, was a strong attraction between two people of the opposite sex. We shared a bond, but for that bond to grow, we needed time, which was not possible, mainly because my calendar was packed with events that made it impossible for me to stay in any one place for a length of time. After a few days I had to hurriedly leave Patiala and had no time to inform Nimmi of my departure. I must sadly admit that my travels and the numerous events that I was competing in soon obliterated all thoughts of Nimmi .

It was during this period of my life that I, too, had begun to experience the adulation and admiration that popular film stars and other celebrities